Tim Schmolka

Hands-on Technical Leader · Payments & Marketplace Systems · Agent-first Development

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SUMMARY

Hands-on engineering leader with 10+ years in backend development, nearly 8 at Kleinanzeigen, Germany's largest classifieds marketplace (40M+ monthly visitors), the last 5 as engineering manager, often doubling as tech lead. Known for de-risked migrations of checkout-critical systems, resilient event-driven design and cross-team reliability standards.

EXPERIENCE

Kleinanzeigen (formerly eBay Kleinanzeigen) · *part of Adevinta, eBay until 2021*

Engineering Manager, Transactions (Payments · Shipping · Promotions) · Tech Lead since 2025 Mar 2023 — Present

- Designed the routing engine that ran both payment service providers (PSPs) side by side for a zero-downtime rollout and sunset in the 5-team switch to Adyen (2025–26), delivered on time in 18 months against a consultancy's 3-year estimate, with 100% of checkouts on Adyen 4 weeks after launch; owned the program's operational health (monitoring, incident response, bug triage, tech debt)
- Led seller onboarding and identity verification (KYC): mapped Adyen's account and verification states onto Kleinanzeigen's seller UX, moved millions of sellers, and built event-driven PSP account management that stays consistent through failures and retries (outbox, idempotent consumers)
- Migrated the legacy promotion engine to Talon.One (promotions platform) in ~3 months as lead developer: ran event-storming to set domain boundaries, wrote the design doc, and de-risked the cut-over with shadow traffic on every checkout and a resilient integration
- Moved the team to agent-first development: Claude Code writes the code, engineers own design, test strategy and review, without compromising quality
- Scaling agent-first across the Transactions department (5 teams) while keeping the codebase maintainable: proposed a north-star module architecture (DDD context map) for the core payment service, plus guardrails that keep agents within it and surface important design decisions to engineers
- Set reliability standards beyond the team: defined the payment service's first service-level objectives (SLOs), wrote the department's incident management standard and a company-wide alerting standard (pending CTO approval), and became co-owner of the company's incident process
- Managed up to 9 engineers (trainee to Staff level)

Engineering Manager & Tech Lead, Motors Jul 2021 — Feb 2023

- Built the Motors (cars) team, responsible for eight-figure annual revenue (2 internal promotions, 100% retention)
- Launched a new revenue stream, now six figures a year, letting private sellers offer their car to dealers via sister marketplace mobile.de: A/B-tested entry points and a gRPC-streaming notification service
- Built a Customer Effort Score feedback service adopted by other teams; co-led a trainee program that hired and mentored 15+ career changers

Senior Software Engineer & Tech Lead, Motors & PRO Jul 2020 — Jun 2021

- Architected and led Motors' extraction from the monolith: hexagonal architecture, own data store, Kafka, AWS via Terraform
- Led engineering for PRO, the subscription product for business sellers (new packages and pricing); moved services from Mesos to Kubernetes
- Wrote the company-wide architecture decision record (ADR) replacing Hystrix with Resilience4j for fault tolerance

Software Engineer Dec 2018 — Jun 2020

- Built the services behind business sellers' shop pages (Kafka-fed caches); maintained the shared gRPC library and load balancing across teams

Mercury.ai

Backend Engineer (part-time from Dec 2018) Apr 2018 — Jul 2019

- Led backend development of an enterprise chatbot-building platform (Java, AWS); introduced CI/CD, code review, centralized logging and autoscaling

Empolis Information Management

Junior Solution Engineer · IT Specialist apprentice Aug 2015 — Mar 2018

- Built enterprise search (Java, Elasticsearch) for patent and public-sector clients; finished the apprenticeship in 2 instead of 3 years

SKILLS

Architecture: distributed systems, system design, event-driven architecture, modular architecture, domain-driven design, architecture decision records
Technologies: Java, Spring Boot, Kafka, gRPC, PostgreSQL, MySQL, Cassandra, BigQuery, TypeScript, Go, Python
Cloud & observability: AWS, GCP, Kubernetes, Terraform, Helm, Argo CD, Grafana, Prometheus
Practices: agentic/agent-first development (Claude Code), SLOs, incident management, staged rollouts, A/B testing, mentoring
Payments & marketplaces: PSPs (Adyen), KYC/onboarding, consent & GDPR, promotions (Talon.One), shipping (DHL, Hermes)
Languages: German (native), English (full professional), Portuguese (elementary)

EDUCATION

State-recognized IT Specialist, Application Development (dual apprenticeship) · *Carl-Severing-Berufskolleg, Bielefeld* Aug 2015 — Jun 2017

AWARDS & RECOGNITIONS

- **Critical Talent Award (2020)**: eBay's highest individual recognition for exceptional impact